



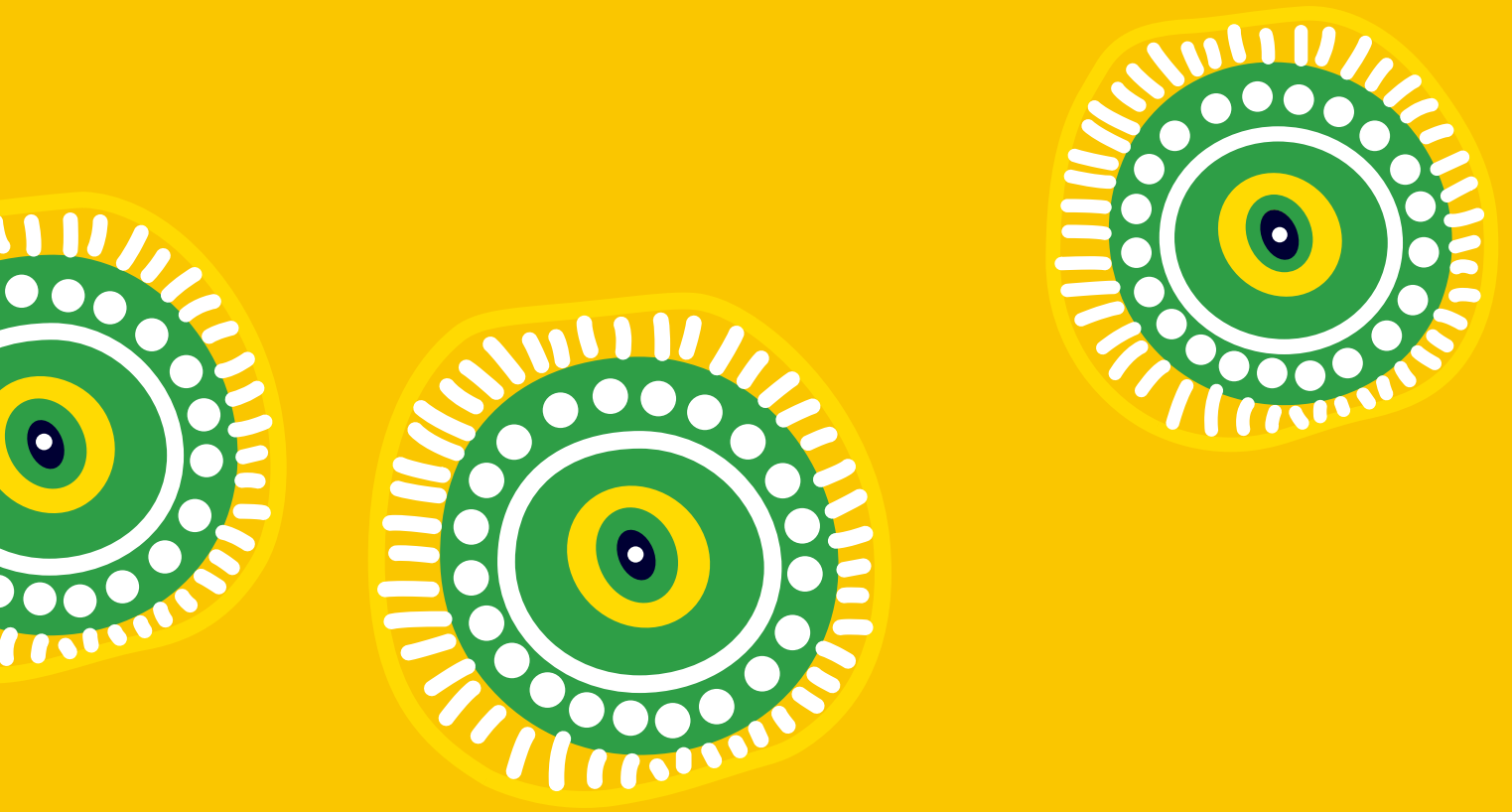
ENHANCE COACH PROGRAM

GUIDELINES, SELECTION CRITERIA, AND APPLICATION PROCESS

July 2026



Australian Government
Australian Sports Commission



Australian Sports Commission Acknowledgement of Country

The Australian Sports Commission (ASC) acknowledges the Traditional Custodians of the lands where its offices are located, the Ngunnawal people and recognise any other people or families with connection to the lands of the ACT and region, the Wurundjeri Woi-wurrung people of the Kulin Nation, the people of the Yugambeh Nation and the Gadigal people of the Eora Nation.

The ASC extends this acknowledgment to all the Traditional Custodians of the lands and First Nations Peoples throughout Australia and would like to pay its respects to all Elders past, present and future.

The ASC recognises the outstanding contribution that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples make to society and sport in Australia and celebrates the power of sport to promote reconciliation and reduce inequality.

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1. ENHANCE Program Overview

The ENHANCE Coach Program is an 18-month learning and development initiative targeting experienced Australian high performance (HP) coaches.

The program aims to develop and support experienced HP coaches (~5-10 years+) by providing opportunities to enhance their knowledge, skills and coaching across a range of areas inclusive of self-awareness, leadership, conflict resolution and systems thinking ensuring they can effectively contribute to the Australian HP sport's vision to "Win Well to inspire Australians."

The 2027-2028 Program will commence in January 2027 and conclude prior to the Los Angeles Olympic and Paralympic Games. Participants will also have the opportunity to engage in a post-Games debrief, providing a reflective connection to the insights, experiences and learnings gained throughout their 18-month development journey.

The ENHANCE Coach Program involves:

- 1 x 3-day/2-night welcome and introductory residential (Late Jan-Early February 2027)
- 3 x 4-day/4-night face to face immersive learning residentials at the AIS
 - Late April-Early May 2027
 - October 2027
 - February 2028
- 1 x 2-day/1-night post-Los Angeles Debrief (October 2028)
- Leadership and support from experienced facilitators as well direct mentoring from a team HP Coach Development Learning Leaders

Between Residentials, coaches within the Program will receive ongoing support and guidance via:

- 3 x whole of cohort online meeting under the guidance of program facilitators
- Regular small group communities of practice under the guidance of HP Coach Development learning leaders
- Regular 1 on 1 meetings with HP Coach Development Learning Leaders

Throughout the course of the program participants will also benefit from:

- Access to experts and leaders, inclusive of mentors and experiences deemed to add value to meeting the program goals
- Peer to peer and cross sport learnings through residentials and small group virtual sessions
- Learning Leaders – selected from the AIS High Performance Coach Development team's most experienced coach development facilitators.

For further information and program details refer to the ENHANCE Coach Program Guide.



2. Program learning objectives

1. **Self-Awareness & Emotional Intelligence:** Analyse the role of emotional intelligence in leadership and coaching approaches by role-modelling self-awareness and regulation strategies to foster trust and collaboration.
2. **Leadership Style:** Critique and reflect on personal leadership skills by reviewing different leadership styles, seeking feedback and demonstrating high moral standards and accountability that inspires trust and confidence.
3. **Wellbeing & Resilience:** Evaluate and implement wellbeing management strategies to optimise health, wellbeing and personal resilience and address real-world coaching challenges.
4. **Psychological Safety:** Lead the integration of psychologically safe principles within coaching practices to create inclusive environments, foster belonging, wellbeing and inclusion within HP environments.
5. **Communication:** Demonstrate and apply individual and group communication skills that promote knowledge sharing, engage athletes and supports collaborative team dynamics.
6. **Conflict Resolution and Difficult Conversations:** Identify and apply the use of structured frameworks that support conflict resolution to manage difficult conversations between athletes, coaches and other HP team members.
7. **Creating HP Environments:** Investigate the characteristics that promote high performing environments and implement evidence-based strategies to optimise program dynamics.
8. **Decision Making under Pressure:** Analyse and reflect on ethical decision making while under pressure and identify opportunities to apply critical thinking processes in high stake moments.
9. **Navigating Australian HP System:** Analyse system structures within the Australian HP environment to identify key levers for navigating political dynamics, improving performance, wellbeing and team culture.
10. **Developing Strategic Relationships:** Evaluate and establish strategic partnerships by developing a stakeholder engagement plan for collaboration within the HP system.
11. **Systems Thinking:** Conceptualise system-based solutions to optimise program goals and coaching effectiveness within HP environment.
12. **Strategic Thinking & Coaching Philosophy:** Apply strategic thinking processes to align personal coaching philosophy with the vision, goals and priorities of the HP program, using frameworks that integrate individual, program, and organisational objectives.

3. Recognised Prior Learning via University of Technology Sydney (UTS)

Since the inception of the ENHANCE Coach Program, significant work has been done in working towards establishing a partnership with an Australian University to investigate the possibility of how the program can be elevated towards a nationally recognised qualification.



The AIS is finalising a partnership arrangement that will enable participants who successfully complete the ENHANCE Coach Program to receive Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL) towards a nationally recognised qualification.

Subject to meeting specified attendance and assessment criteria, coaches will be eligible to receive 50% Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL) of the Graduate Certificate in High Performance Sport through the University of Technology Sydney (UTS).

Entry and selection into the Program are not bound by a coach's decision to pursue the UTS Graduate Certificate in High Performance Coaching.

More details related to this opportunity will be provided to selected candidates when the Program commences.

4. Application process and key dates

System Briefing	Thursday 6 th August 2026 at 3:00pm
Applications Open	Friday 7 th August 2026
Applications Close	Monday 14 th September 2026 (4:00pm AEST)
How to Apply	Applications should be submitted online using the <u>ENHANCE Coach Program application form</u>. To support accessibility considerations, contact Program Lead to discuss alternatives. Email contact: hpcoachdevelopment@ausport.gov.au The application form should be completed in full by the coach candidate, and all required documentation attached. This will include: • Current CV. • Declaration of NSO/D and NIN partner (where applicable) endorsement which includes: ○ Signed letter of support from Performance Director, CEO or other appropriate organisation representative outlining the coach's experience and potential to lead and impact coaching within the sport across future Olympic, Paralympic and Commonwealth Games cycles.

	○ How the program is expected to be of benefit to the applying coach and the organisation. ○ Acknowledgement by the NSO/D and/or NIN of financial support being provided to the endorsed coach to attend Residentials. ○ Acknowledgement by the NSO/D and or NIN of support for the endorsed coach to prioritise and attend the identified Residentials. For complete application process refer to Section 6 and for eligibility requirements refer to Section 4. Coaches who have previously attended the historical Podium Coach Program run by the AIS are eligible for consideration but will need to present a case as to why the ENHANCE Coach Program will be beneficial.
Consultation Period	Wednesday 15 th July – Friday 14 th August 2026
Interviews	Monday 5 th October – Friday 30 th October 2026
Panel Assessment Period	Monday 2 nd November – Friday 13 th November 2026
Outcome Notification	Monday 30 th November 2026
Program Commencement	Monday 11 th January 2027
Key Program Dates	• Late Jan-Early February 2027 • Late April-Early May 2027 • October 2027 • February 2028 • October 2028

Submission of an application does not guarantee selection. The AIS retains absolute discretion in the final selection of participants.



5. Eligibility criteria

5.1 Organisational Eligibility & Endorsement

Organisations considering submitting applicants for the ENHANCE Coach program must:

- Meet the National HP Sport Eligibility criteria
- Receive ASC HP investment in the 2026-27 financial year

Applicants must be Employed or contracted by an NSO, NSOD or NIN.

The employing organisation must demonstrate an active commitment to the coach's development and progression within the high performance system, including support for:

- Participation in all required program components and activities.
- Ongoing development opportunities aligned to the coach's performance pathway.
- The application of learning and insights gained through the program within the coach's performance environment.

Where an applicant is employed by a NIN to deliver an NSO/D program, both the NIN and NSO/D must jointly endorse the application and demonstrate a shared commitment to the coach's ongoing development and progression.

Organisational endorsement is required for all applicants and must include a statement of support (maximum 250 words) from the Performance Director, HPM or other appropriate organisational representative confirming:

- The applicant's current role and level of experience within the high performance system.
- Organisational support for the applicant's participation, including availability for all program components.
- Commitment to supporting the applicant's ongoing development and application of learning within the performance environment.
- Commitment to active involvement in the program activities outlined below.

The Performance Director, HPM or other appropriate organisational representative will be expected to:

- Participate in mid-program and end-of-program review meetings to discuss the participant's progress.
- Engage with program facilitators to understand program content and identify opportunities to support the participant's learning and application within the performance environment.

5.2 Coach Eligibility

Coach applicants must:



- Be currently employed or contracted by an NSO, NSOD or NIN as a HP coach; AND have a minimum 5+ years' experience; AND currently be coaching athletes competing in senior international competition.
- Be considered by the NSO/D and/or NIN as highly likely to deliver athletes to the Australian Los Angeles Olympic/Paralympic team and/or coach within the Los Angeles Olympic/Paralympic team environment. AND/OR
- Be considered by the NSO/D and/or NIN as highly likely to deliver athletes to the Australian French Alps Winter Olympic/Paralympic team and/or coach within the French Alps Winter Olympic/Paralympic environment.
- Be considered by the NSO/D and/or NIN as highly likely to deliver athletes to the 2030 Australian Ahmedabad Commonwealth Games team and/or coach within the Ahmedabad Commonwealth Games environment.
- Be committed to pursuing HP coaching as an ongoing career of choice.

Additionally, Coach applicants must:

- Be an Australian citizen or hold permanent residence status
- Be available for all mandatory program components and dates
- Hold a current Working with Vulnerable People (relevant State/Territory) where applicable
- Agree to be bound by the Integrity policies, Code of Conduct, Code of Ethics, and anti-doping policies of the ASC, and relevant NSO/NSOD and NIN partner
- Meet all SIA and AIS Integrity requirements

5.3 Inclusion of External Applicants

A limited number of places may be offered to individuals from adjacent or external performance environments where participation is deemed to add demonstrable value to the ENHANCE Coach Program and participants within the program.

For clarity, if a decision is taken to include external participants this will not displace eligible HP system applicants, and these positions will be additions to the 24 positions. These will also incur a fee for service arrangement beyond the current financial expectations governing eligible HP system applicants.

External applicants may include individuals from:

- Professional sporting codes
- High Performance environments outside the national system
- Aligned performance sectors where learning exchange is beneficial

External applicants may be offered places where participation:

- Does not displace eligible High Performance system applicants
- Adds demonstrable value to cohort learning through experience, perspective, or expertise
- Aligns with the purpose and learning outcomes of the program
- Provides potential broader benefit to the High Performance sport system, including future collaboration, knowledge exchange, or leadership contribution

External participants will be required to pay a program participation fee on a fee for service basis. Any fees applied do not influence selection decisions, which remain merit based. Applicants will be

required to meet all other program eligibility requirements including but not limited to Safeguarding and Integrity standards. For further information, including the fee structure contact hpcoachdevelopment@ausport.gov.au

5.4 Eligibility Assessment

Applicants must be initially deemed 'eligible' by meeting the programs minimum eligibility threshold (see 5.2) as well as organisational endorsement criteria (see 5.1) before being considered for selection.

6. Selection process

On the completion of an eligibility assessment all applications will be assessed by a Selection Panel against the selection criteria identified in 6.2.

Applicants deemed to meet the selection criteria will then be expected to attend an interview to further assess suitability for the program.

The panel will apply consistent assessment criteria to all applications to arrive at a final recommendation to the Program Lead.

Final approval will be required by the Director of AIS HP Coach Development and the AIS Director.

6.1 Selection Panel Composition

Refer to Part C (Assessment Panel Guide) for full guidance on panel composition, scoring, and process. As a minimum, the panel will include:

- Program Lead
- Subject Matter Expert(s)
- Independent Reviewer

Any panel member with a conflict of interest in relation to any applicant must declare it prior to assessment and may be excluded from reviewing that application.

6.2 Selection Criteria

The Selection Panel will assess each eligible application via a two-step process:

1. Selection Criteria:
 - **Capability Alignment:** Evidence of relevant experience, skills, and capability appropriate to the program. (Reference the HP Coach Development Framework).
 - **Learning Objectives Fit:** Clarity and strength of evidence that the applicant will benefit from and contribute to the program learning objectives.
 - **Potential Impact:** Likely application of learning within the applicant's role, team, and organisation; contribution to the HP system.



- **Cohort Considerations:** Contribution to a balanced cohort including diversity of gender, geographic spread, sport type (Olympic, Paralympic, Commonwealth Games, action/lifestyle), and career stage, performance support discipline.
2. Coach Interview:
- **Understanding of Program:** This will include understanding of expected commitments, ability to manage time and prioritise as well participate and contribute to all elements of the program.

6.3 Number of Coaches Selected to Program

Up to 24 coaches may be selected for the program, the final number being at the discretion of the Selection Panel and dependent on the quality of the applications and considerations as noted in these guidelines.

As identified and set out in Section 5.3, consideration may be given to external applications.

For clarity if a decision is taken to include external participants this will not displace eligible HP system applicants, and these positions will be additions to the 24 positions.

6.4 Special Consideration

The Selection Panel may, at its discretion, accept a limited number of special consideration applications that fall outside standard eligibility criteria where a workable solution has been proposed, and selection would be in the best interest of all parties and the program.

6.5 Safeguarding and Integrity

When the Selection Panel has identified a recommended cohort, the cohort list including participants full name, role title and organisation will be sent to both Sport Integrity Australia and the ASC Director of Safeguarding and Integrity for review and endorsement.

Where any safeguarding or integrity concerns are raised, the participant in question's selection in the program will be reviewed accordingly. Where the recommended cohort list is endorsed by both Sport Integrity Australia and Director of Safeguarding and Integrity, it can proceed to Director of AIS HP Coach Development and the AIS Director for final approval.

7. Application Components

Application information should be submitted through [**ENHANCE Coach Program application form**](#).

For accessibility, alternative formats will be supported. Please contact the Program Lead to discuss.

Applicants will be required to submit the following information:

- Personal details and demographics, including any additional learning or participation support needs.



- Role details – role title, employment status and years of experience.
- Organisational endorsement – Performance Director, HPM or other appropriate organisational representative contact details and role title as well as statement of endorsement.
- Capability statement describing relevant experience, skills, achievements, or prior learning. Identification of potential growth opportunities that would be valuable. (300 words maximum).
- Alignment to program objectives: a statement describing how participation in this program will contribute to your personal development and the development of your organisation or sport. This should include reference to long term coaching goals and underpinning coaching philosophy (300 words maximum).
- Commitment and availability declaration for attendance at all program components.
- Evidence of current Working with Vulnerable People (or state equivalent).
- Current CV or other supporting documentation.

8. Terms and Conditions — Longitudinal Program

If the Australian Sports Commission (**ASC**) decides to offer the applicant the opportunity to attend the ENHANCE Coach Program the offer (**Offer**) will be made subject to these terms and conditions.

1. These terms and conditions, together with the notification from the AIS providing details of the Offer (**Successful Email**), will constitute an enforceable agreement between the AIS and the successful applicant (**Recipient**) upon the Recipient accepting the Offer, as required by the Successful Email.
2. The Recipient agrees to attend all mandatory components of the ENHANCE Coach Program as detailed in their Successful Email (**Activity**).
3. The Recipient declares and warrants, at the date of agreeing to these terms and conditions, that they have not at any time been found to have breached any anti-doping rule or policy applicable to the Recipient, and has not engaged at any time in any conduct that constituted a breach of any anti-doping rule or policy applicable to the Recipient.
4. The Recipient agrees to be bound by, and comply with, the Integrity policies, Code of Conduct, Code of Ethics, and anti-doping policies of the ASC, and relevant NSO/NSOD and NIN or Games delivery partner (where applicable). This includes a Sport Integrity Australia check.
5. The Recipient must respect the privacy and confidentiality of all program materials, peer contributions, and information shared within the program environment.
6. The Recipient agrees to provide honest and constructive feedback for program evaluation purposes as requested by the AIS.
7. A Recipient who withdraws from the program after acceptance may be replaced by a waitlisted applicant. Withdrawal should be confirmed in writing to the AIS, NSO/D, and NIN partner (where applicable) at the earliest opportunity.
8. Submission of an application does not guarantee selection. The AIS retains absolute discretion in the final selection of Recipients.
9. Organisational endorsement is required to confirm support for the Recipient's participation and the application of their learning throughout and following the program.

10. The personal details of Recipients (including name, home state, sport, and any photo or video footage produced in connection with the ENHANCE Coach Program may be released by the AIS to the public and the media for promotional and educational purposes.
11. The AIS may terminate a Recipient's participation by written notice if: (a) the Recipient fails to comply terms outlined; or (b) the AIS, at its absolute discretion, determines that it is inappropriate for the Recipient to continue participating in the program.
12. A Recipient's position may also be terminated if the Recipient: brings the ENHANCE Coach Program and/or the NSO/NSOD, NIN or Games delivery partner, or ASC/AIS into disrepute; does not commit to the requirements of the program; or is not making satisfactory progress as reasonably determined by the AIS.
13. The AIS reserves the right to cancel, suspend, postpone, or vary the nature of the ENHANCE Coach Program at any time and for any reason.
14. The AIS will not be liable to any person for any loss, damage, or claim arising from the program or such variation, cancellation, suspension, or postponement.
15. In the event of early departure or termination, any unused professional development funds or grants payments will be required to be repaid to the AIS.
16. These terms and conditions are governed by the law of the Australian Capital Territory.

9. Feedback and Appeals

Unsuccessful applicants may request feedback on their application by contacting the Program Lead hpcoachdevelopment@ausport.gov.au within 3 business days of receiving notification of the outcome.

The AIS is committed to a fair and transparent process. If an applicant believes that the selection process was not conducted in accordance with these guidelines, they may raise a concern in writing by contacting hpcoachdevelopment@ausport.gov.au within 3 business days of notification.





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